

# Renzo Piano

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**I**talian architect and engineer Renzo Piano (b.1937) was cited by *TIME* magazine in 2006 as one of the world's 100 most influential people. An habitual collaborator, he worked for Louis Kahn in Philadelphia, with Richard Rogers (notably producing the Pompidou Centre) and with engineer Peter Rice (1935–92) before setting up his own independent firm in 1981.

Piano's portfolio is hugely diverse in both style, materials and techniques used, but is always concerned with habitability and sustainability. The Menil Collection Museum in Houston (1982) is a low, articulated box of concrete reinforced with steel girders. In 2006 he extended the Morgan Library in Manhattan, using a deliberately plain design so as not to detract from the original 1903 building. His California Academy of Sciences in San Francisco (2008) has a 'living roof' that is vital to the building's heating and cooling efficiency. The Shard in London (opposite) – a giant, pyramidal glass spire rising 309.6 metres (1,016ft) from a tiny split-level site – was completed in 2012.

